

Pittsburgh - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Solid bowl-caliber / middle-ACC quality with a settled QB, veteran OL core and a defense whose 2025 efficiency gives the rebuild a credible floor.
Preseason consensus	AP others receiving votes (7 points) · ACC media 9th (1,740 points) · SP+ No. 41
Returning production	58% (No. 43) overall · Off. 60% (No. 48) · Def. 56% (No. 52)
Primer power rating	+6.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.9 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - Slightly worse, but still bowl-caliber
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Kade Bell can build the offense directly around settled QB Mason Heintschel, clear RB Ja’Kyrian Turner and a veteran OL core, using speed and space to improve down-to-down efficiency. Cory Sanders inherits the defensive play-calling role inside Pat Narduzzi’s program, with returning edge starters and a deep corner rotation trying to preserve a 2025 defense that was much better than its scoring rank.

Bottom line: Pitt has enough QB/OL/edge continuity for bowl contention, but major WR/LB/DB losses make another eight-win season less bankable.

Beats expectations if: QB Mason Heintschel improves offensive success rate, the veteran OL controls havoc and the defense preserves 2025 efficiency through turnover.

Disappoints if: The rebuilt pass-catcher group stalls, third-down offense remains poor and LB/secondary losses drag the defense toward its SP+ No. 54 projection.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Mason Heintschel is the unquestioned QB1 and the 2026 offense is being built around him; this is a much more settled quarterback picture than many mid-tier ACC peers.
- 2 2025 baseline:** Pitt’s 2025 defense was better than the 24.8 pts/g scoring rank implies: defensive EPA/play allowed No.18, success rate allowed No.16, rush defense No.8 and havoc created No.17.
- 3 Offensive line:** The offense returns three recognized OL anchors-OL Ryan Baer, OL BJ Williams and C Ryan Carretta-while transfer OT Netinho Olivieri is holding down left tackle; left guard remains the main line competition.
- 4 ? Key uncertainty:** Turnover is substantial despite 58% returning production: nine significant departures to professional football, and leading WR Raphael “Poppi” Williams Jr. plus DB Kavir Bains-Marquez are eligibility/graduation losses with no confirmed pro destinations.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.58 (6/10); the season-defining stretch is at Miami, Georgia Tech, Florida State and at Louisville, with a bye before Florida State.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (6-2 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	33.7 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	390.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	117.2 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	7.66 YPA · 29 TD / 15 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	33.3%	● Poor
Scoring defense	24.8 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	330.4 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	95.1 YPG · 2.7 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	235.3 YPG · 7.10 YPA · 28 TD allowed	● Below average

Pitt scored at a high level (33.7 pts/g, No.20) but the offense was less stable underneath that total: total offense No.67, rush offense No.115 and third-down conversion No.120. Defense was much stronger in yardage and run control than scoring rank alone shows, finishing No.32 in total defense and No.8 in rush defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.25 · No. 30	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.015 · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	40.2% · No. 100	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	13.1% · No. 46	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	18.0% · No. 116	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.88 · No. 31	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.126 · No. 18	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	36.6% · No. 16	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.3% · No. 32	● Very good
Havoc created	18.4% · No. 17	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Pitt’s 2025 profile was a split story: scoring output and opponent-adjusted offense were strong enough to matter, but success rate, third downs and havoc allowed show why the offense could be uneven. The defense was much more trustworthy-top-32 across adjusted efficiency, EPA allowed, success rate allowed, explosive prevention, rush defense and havoc created-so 2026 downside comes less from scheme identity than from whether the new second-level/back-end personnel can maintain that standard.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Pat Narduzzi - returning	● ↔ Keeps Pitt's program identity and defensive philosophy stable through roster turnover.
OC / play-caller	Kade Bell - returning OC/QBs and offensive play-caller	● ↑ The same coordinator and play-caller preserves offensive terminology and game-day continuity.
DC / play-caller	◆ Cory Sanders - promoted internally from assistant HC/safeties; defensive play-caller; promoted internally from assistant HC/safeties	● ↔ Transition adds uncertainty; caller established

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ OT Netinho Olivieri	Pennsylvania	● ↔ Is holding down left tackle and is the lone projected OL starter who is not a returner.
◆ RB La'Vell Wright	Western Kentucky	● ↔ Veteran rotation help behind clear RB1 RB Ja'Kyrian Turner, useful after losing RB Desmond Reid and RB Juelz Goff.
◆ TE Carson Kent	Oklahoma	● ↔ Part of a veteran top-two TE projection, but exact TE1 hierarchy is not settled.

Out	To	Loss
WR Raphael "Poppi" Williams Jr.	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ The 2025 receiving leader (51-701-7) exits with no confirmed professional destination.
RB Desmond Reid	NFL (Buffalo), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A material 2025 backfield contributor exits to a confirmed NFL signing, increasing reliance on RB Ja'Kyrian Turner and transfer depth.
RB Juelz Goff	Boise State	● ↔ A 12-game rotation back with 270 rushing yards and five TDs leaves.
WR Kenny Johnson	Texas Tech	● ↓ Another material receiver exits from a room that already loses its leading 2025 target.

Offensive net: ● ↓ modest downgrade in proven skill depth, partially offset by QB/OL continuity and transfer role players

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DB Raion Strader	Auburn	● ↔ Narduzzi views him as a current starter, giving the rebuilt secondary a credible starter-level transfer.
◆ LB Alex Sanford Jr.	Purdue	● ↔ Adds Power 4 linebacker depth to a room replacing high-value production.

Out	To	Loss
LB Kyle Louis	NFL (Miami), Round 5, No. 138	● ↓ A material 2025 linebacker departs as a fourth-round NFL draft pick.
LB Rasheem Biles	Texas	● ↓ Another material linebacker departure increases pressure on LB Braylan Lovelace and the transfer rebuild.
DL Francis Brewu	Notre Dame	● ↓ A material front departure reduces continuity even with two returning edge starters.
DB Kavir Bains-Marquez	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ A 58-tackle, three-interception defender exits with no confirmed professional destination.

Defensive net: ● ↓ modest downgrade from a strong 2025 baseline, with enough returning edge/corner structure to avoid a full reset

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Bell's speed-and-space offense is being tailored around QB Mason Heintschel's command, with RB Ja'Kyrian Turner as the clear RB1 and a veteran line expected to support explosive-play creation.	Settled QB/RB roles, three recognized returning OL anchors and a 2025 scoring offense that ranked No.20.	Receiver hierarchy is rebuilt, left guard is open, and the 2025 offense ranked No.100 in success rate, No.120 on third down and No.116 in havoc allowed.
Defense	A Narduzzi program defense now called by internal promotion Cory Sanders, built on physical/fast secondary play, returning edge starters and a deeper rotation.	2025 efficiency was legitimately strong: EPA/play allowed No.18, success rate allowed No.16, rush defense No.8 and havoc created No.17.	LB Kyle Louis/LB Rasheem Biles and multiple veteran DB departures create more second-level/back-end projection than the returning edge picture suggests.
Special teams	A transfer-rebuilt specialist operation rather than a continuity strength.	The staff imported direct kicker, punter and long-snapper options.	No proven 2026 specialist hierarchy is established yet.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	High	QB Mason Heintschel is the settled starter, giving the offense a stable floor.
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-high	The backfield has a clear lead option but less proven depth after major departures.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Medium	WR Censere Lee supplies continuity in a receiver room replacing meaningful 2025 production.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	The tight-end hierarchy is unsettled after meaningful 2025 production departs.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	OL Ryan Baer and veteran returners provide continuity while LG remains open.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	Returning front pieces preserve a credible base despite meaningful turnover.
LB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	A proven linebacker core supports the defense despite departures around it.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium	Returning DB talent remains, but multiple veteran losses reduce continuity.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	Kicker, punter and long-snapper roles are being rebuilt with limited certainty.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Pat Narduzzi and OC Kade Bell return while the defensive caller changes internally.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	Bowl-caliber with a settled QB, veteran OL and a credible defensive floor.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Mason Heintschel	QB	● Solid Power 4 starter projection / offensive fulcrum	Maxwell	He is the unquestioned QB1 and the offense is explicitly being built around his command.
Ja'Kyrian Turner	RB	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	-	Clear RB1 after leading Pitt rushing late in 2025; he must absorb more backfield responsibility after Reid/Goff departures.
Cataurus Hicks	WR	● Lead-target candidate / proven returning starter	-	Only returning 2025 WR starter (24 catches, 422 yards, four TDs) in a room replacing its leading receiver.
Ryan Baer	OL	● High-end conference OL anchor	Outland	One of three recognized veteran OL anchors protecting a settled quarterback.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
BJ Williams	OL	● High-end conference OL anchor	Outland	Part of the returning senior line core that gives the offense more continuity than the skill positions.
Ryan Carretta	C	● Proven center / OL anchor	Rimington	Centers the veteran interior while left guard remains the one explicit line competition.
Braylan Lovelace	LB	● High-end conference defender / unit leader	Bednarik · Butkus	The front-seven headliner shifts from MIKE to outside linebacker while the room replaces LB Kyle Louis and LB Rasheem Biles.
Jimmy Scott	DL	● Proven Power 4 edge starter	-	Third-year starter and 2025 DL sack leader anchors the most settled part of the defense.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable enough for bowl expectations, but the late ACC run can separate a 6-6/7-5 team from another 8-win season.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 58
Hardest stretch	at Miami → Georgia Tech → Florida State → at Louisville (bye before Florida State)
Swing games	at Virginia Tech, North Carolina, Georgia Tech, Florida State, at California
Advantage	The first four games are all at home, including Miami (OH), UCF, Syracuse and Bucknell, giving the new skill rotation time before five of the final eight are away from home.
Expected	6.9 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Pitt should be priced more as an offense-led team than its defense-first reputation implies: settled QB/OL structure is the cleanest advantage, while defensive turnover creates the wider outcome range.
Back them when	QB Mason Heintschel and the OL have a protection/efficiency edge and the opponent is vulnerable to Pitt's physical front or cannot exploit the rebuilt receiver/linebacker depth.
Fade/pass when	Against defenses that create havoc and force long-yardage offense, or opponents with enough receiving depth to stress the reshuffled linebacker/secondary personnel.
Key monitor	left guard winner, WR hierarchy/Censere Lee role, three-corner rotation order, Crothers/Jaeden Moore availability
Week 1 baseline	rating-only fair baseline Pittsburgh –12.0 ; Pittsburgh primer +6.0 minus Miami-OH final preseason SP+ proxy -4.0 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment Live market: Pittsburgh –16.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Pittsburgh has a stable quarterback and enough veteran line/defensive structure to remain a credible bowl team, but the skill-position hierarchy and specialist operation are less settled than the headline continuity suggests.

The defensive front/linebacker base gives HC Pat Narduzzi's team a workable floor, while secondary turnover and offensive replacement questions create variance. The baseline remains **6.9 wins · likely 7-5**, with value dependent on how quickly those new roles settle.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#)

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